

TEAM DISCUSSION GUIDE

NeuroAdaptive Leadership®

A Leader's Guide for Facilitating Team Conversations

ABOUT THIS GUIDE

This guide is built for leaders who want to work through the book together with their colleagues or team. Each session below pairs a chapter with a short set of discussion questions and a facilitator tip.

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

- **Pace:** one chapter per session (ten sessions) or two chapters per session (five sessions). Pick what fits your group's rhythm.
- **Ask everyone to read the chapter before you meet.** Five minutes of silent skimming at the start works if time is tight.
- **Budget 45 to 60 minutes per session:** a few minutes to open, the discussion questions, and a closing commitment.
- **Start and end on time.** Predictability builds the psychological safety this book is all about.
- **You don't need every question.** Pick the two or three that fit where your group is right now.

THE A.D.A.P.T. MODEL AT A GLANCE

Attune to Disruption: notice change before it hijacks your thinking.

Decode Thought Patterns: catch the story before it drives the decision.

Align Identity and Intention: make your actions match who you say you are.

Program Adaptivity: turn a new response into your new default.

Transfer Through Culture: make adaptability a habit your team catches too.

01

THE CONTEXT FOR NEUROADAPTIVE LEADERSHIP

Chapter 1: Leadership in the Age of Disruption

Disruption is the new normal, and the brain's default response can work for a leader or against them. This session is about naming the team's real patterns, not the polished version.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Think about the last few months. What's one change that really tested how well you adapted? How did you respond: freeze, control, avoid, or get curious?
2. Where do you see our team defaulting to "the way we've always done it" instead of adapting? What does that cost us?
3. What idea from this chapter felt most true to what's happening on our team right now?
4. What's one place, as a team, where we could practice more mental agility this month?

FACILITATOR TIP

People often blame disruption itself (“if things would just calm down”). Steer the conversation toward what we can control: our response, rather than wishing the disruption away.

02

UPGRADING YOUR LEADERSHIP OPERATING SYSTEM

Chapter 2: Upgrading From the Inside Out

Traditional leadership skills still matter, but they aren’t enough on their own. Real growth starts with upgrading how the brain works, not just what we know.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Where do you feel the demands of leadership landing hardest right now: attention, emotional regulation, or decision-making?
2. Neuroplasticity means the brain can change with practice. What’s a belief you’ve held about yourself as a leader (“I’ve always been this way”) that this chapter makes you want to question?
3. What stood out most in this chapter, and why does it matter for how our team leads?
4. What’s one small, repeatable action we could each commit to over the next 30 days to start upgrading how we think or lead?

FACILITATOR TIP

This chapter asks people to question long-held self-beliefs. Model some openness yourself first. Share a belief you’re questioning before asking the group to go there.

03

THE A.D.A.P.T. MODEL · YOUR BLUEPRINT

Chapter 3: The Brain’s Blueprint for Adaptivity

This chapter introduces the five-part A.D.A.P.T. model: Attune, Decode, Align, Program, and Transfer. It’s the blueprint the rest of the book builds on.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Of the five A.D.A.P.T. skills, which one seems to be our team’s current strength? Which feels like our growth edge?
2. The book says reactivity, rigidity, and burnout usually reflect poor brain-system integration, not a lack of intelligence. Does that change how we respond when a teammate is struggling?
3. What part of the neuroscience in this chapter stood out most, or felt most useful?
4. As we move into Chapters 4 through 8, which A.D.A.P.T. skill should our group focus on first, and why?

FACILITATOR TIP

Use Question 4 to set the tone for the rest of the series. Write down the group’s answer somewhere visible and revisit it in your final session.

04

A.D.A.P.T. SKILL 1 · ATTUNE TO DISRUPTION

Chapter 4: Attune to Disruption

Attuning means noticing disruption, inside you and around you, before it hijacks your thinking. The more a leader expects change, the less it can surprise them.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What are the most common disruptions you're each scanning for right now, big and small?
2. Of the four attuning practices (Disruption Scanning, Emotional Tracking, Box Breathing, and the OODA Loop), which would help our team most, and why?
3. What did Sarah's boardroom story teach you about what happens when we don't attune in the moment?
4. What's one attuning practice you'll each try this week? How will you know it worked?

FACILITATOR TIP

Consider opening this session with 60 seconds of box breathing as a group before you dive in. It makes the chapter's point without saying a word.

05

A.D.A.P.T. SKILL 2 · DECODE THOUGHT PATTERNS

Chapter 5: Decode Thought Patterns

Thoughts feel like facts, but many are just old, well-worn shortcuts. Decoding means catching the story before it drives the decision.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Of the five thinking errors (bias, overconfidence, pattern hunger, emotional reasoning, and cognitive laziness), which shows up most in our team's conversations?
2. Think of a recent moment of friction on the team. Using the 3R Method, what was the automatic thought, and what's a more accurate reframe?
3. What stood out most in this chapter, or felt most relevant to a pattern you recognize in yourself?
4. What's one decoding practice we could use together the next time tension shows up in a meeting?

FACILITATOR TIP

Keep this conversation focused on patterns, not people. If someone starts pointing at a specific teammate's "story," redirect to the general pattern instead.

06

A.D.A.P.T. SKILL 3 · ALIGN IDENTITY AND INTENTION

Chapter 6: Align Identity and Intention

When identity and action match, leadership feels natural instead of forced. This chapter closes the gap between who a leader says they are and how they actually show up.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. This chapter distinguishes purpose (your why) from mission (how you live it out). If you had to state your leadership purpose in one sentence, what would you say?
2. What did the Mulally story reveal about the cost, or the power, of staying aligned under pressure?
3. Think of a moment you acted in a way that didn't match who you want to be as a leader. What pulled you out of alignment? Share only what feels comfortable.
4. How aligned is our team's stated culture with how we actually operate day to day? Where's the biggest gap?

FACILITATOR TIP

This one can get personal. Normalize that everyone gets pulled out of alignment sometimes. The goal is awareness, not confession.

07

A.D.A.P.T. SKILL 4 · PROGRAM ADAPTIVITY

Chapter 7: Program Adaptivity

Insight alone doesn't change behavior. Repetition does. Programming adaptivity is how a new response becomes the new default.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Marcus rewired his "freeze" response with a new operating script. What's a default reaction, yours or the team's, you'd like to reprogram?
2. Pick one common habit on the team, helpful or not. Using Habit Loop Mapping, what's the cue, the routine, and the real reward behind it?
3. What stood out most about how the brain builds, and can rebuild, its patterns?
4. What would it take for a new, more adaptive response to become our team's new default?

FACILITATOR TIP

If time allows, have each person draft one line of a personal "operating script" during the session: a scripted first move for a moment they usually mishandle.

08

A.D.A.P.T. SKILL 5 · TRANSFER THROUGH CULTURE

Chapter 8: Transfer Through Culture

A leader's nervous system is contagious. This final skill turns personal adaptability into a habit the whole team can catch.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. This chapter says a team "downloads" a leader's nervous system through mirror neurons. What is your current stress response teaching the people around you?
2. Of the four transferring practices (NeuroAdaptive Modeling, Feedback Rituals, Story Modeling, and Symbolic Reinforcement), which is most missing on our team right now?
3. What stood out most in this chapter: Elena's story, the neuroscience, or one of the practices?

4. What's one specific, visible thing we'll do in the next two weeks to start transferring neuroadaptive behavior into our team's culture?

FACILITATOR TIP

This is a natural closing chapter for the core A.D.A.P.T. series. Consider ending the session with a group commitment everyone can see and hold each other to.

09-10

KNOW YOUR STARTING POINT · FROM INSIGHT TO ACTION

Chapters 9 and 10: Assessing Your NeuroAdaptability & Building a Plan

Before a leader can strengthen their neuroadaptability, they need to see it clearly. Then they can build one simple, focused plan instead of trying to fix everything at once. Ask everyone to complete the NLI (NeuroAdaptiveLeadership.com/NLI) and their Workbook pages for Chapters 9 and 10 before this session.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Without sharing exact numbers, what surprised you most about your NLI scores?
2. Which A.D.A.P.T. skill did you each choose as your priority, and why that one?
3. What's the one lead behavior you're committing to for your 30-day sprint?
4. How can we support each other's sprints as a team? What would a useful weekly check-in look like?

FACILITATOR TIP

This session works best as your closing meeting. Ask everyone to bring their completed Workbook pages and be ready to state their priority skill and lead behavior out loud. Public commitments tend to stick.

WRAPPING UP THE SERIES

- A. Looking back across all ten chapters, what's the single biggest shift in how you lead?
- B. What's one way we'll keep this conversation alive as a team after this series ends?

KEEP GOING

If NeuroAdaptive Leadership resonated with your team, they may also enjoy Dr. Jones's book **Activator: Using Brain Science to Boost Motivation, Deepen Engagement, and Supercharge Performance**. For keynotes, workshops, or coaching, contact Info@DrJasonJones.com or visit DrJasonJones.com.

ABOUT DR. JASON JONES

Dr. Jason Jones is an organizational psychologist, executive coach, and international keynote speaker who helps leaders think more clearly and lead with greater agility under pressure. He is the creator of NeuroAdaptive Leadership® and founder of LeaderPath, where his clients have included Microsoft, IBM, Porsche, AT&T, American Airlines, and the Dallas Cowboys. He is also the author of *Activator* and *28 Days to a Motivated Team*.